

YOUR IDEA IS AHEAD OF YOUR EVIDENCE.

Every founder starts here. The gap right now isn't your idea or your effort — it's that the evidence for it mostly lives in your head.

VENTURE SIGNAL Building the Foundation	BUILD STATUS No build yet
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YOUR SINGLE HIGHEST-LEVERAGE MOVE

Have **5 real conversations** with people who match your buyer — not friends, not family. That's what actually changes the read on this venture, fast.

WHAT YOU TOLD US

Customer conversations so far	None yet
Can you name the exact buyer?	Not yet — it's more of a general audience
What they do about it today	Honestly, I'm not sure
Real commitment shown	Not yet
How much is built	Just an idea so far
Business entity	Not yet — haven't looked into it

WHY THIS IS THE MOVE

Right now, the biggest credibility gap with anyone who might back this — an investor, a partner, a future hire — isn't your product. It's proof someone besides you has this problem. That's a fast thing to close, not a slow one, once you know how to ask.

As a technical founder, this usually isn't a build problem — it's a proof problem. The instinct is to keep shipping; the credibility investors and customers actually check for is whether anyone asked for it first.

The fastest way to change the read on this venture isn't building more — it's five conversations with people who match your buyer. Here's how to run them so what you hear is actually usable.

HOW TO OPEN

You're not selling, and it helps to say so out loud: *"I'm not here to pitch you anything — I'm trying to understand how you handle this today."* Then stop talking. You want to hear what already happened, not what someone imagines they might do.

SIX QUESTIONS THAT GET YOU REAL ANSWERS

- 1. Walk me through the last time you dealt with this. What actually happened?
- 2. What did you do about it — step by step?
- 3. What did that cost you in time, money, or hassle?
- 4. Had you looked for a better way? What did you find, and why didn't you stick with it?
- 5. Who else was involved in deciding what to do?
- 6. What would have to be true for you to handle it differently next time?

WHAT QUIETLY INVALIDATES A CONVERSATION

- Describing your solution before the questions are done — once someone knows what you want to hear, you can't unhear their politeness.
- Hypotheticals: "would you use this?", "what would you pay?" Stated intent predicts very little about behavior.
- Counting enthusiasm as evidence. "That's a great idea" is the most common thing a founder hears right before nothing happens.
- Talking mostly to friends, family, or anyone who wants you to succeed.

CONVERSATION LOG

WHO + THEIR ROLE	DATE	WHAT THEY DO ABOUT IT TODAY	WHAT SURPRISED ME

Five is roughly where patterns start to show. If four of five describe the same workaround, you've found something real. If all five describe something different, the problem isn't shared yet — which is also worth knowing before you build.

These are the signals investors, partners, and serious customers tend to check — at any stage, in any industry. None of them are OM's invention, and none of them require anyone's permission to start working on. Here's where your own answers put you today.

SIGNAL	WHAT IT MEANS IN PRACTICE	WHERE YOU ARE TODAY
Customer evidence	Conversations with real potential buyers about what they actually did — not what they say they might do.	NOT YET
A named buyer	A specific role you can describe, including how their day works — not a demographic or a market segment.	NOT YET
The current workaround	What people do about this today, seen or heard firsthand. It's what you're really competing against.	NOT YET
Real commitment	Money, a signature, access, or scheduled time. Verbal interest is common; committed action is rare and it's what gets remembered.	NOT YET
Build maturity <i>tracked separately</i>	How much exists today. Deliberately kept apart from the signals above — a working product doesn't substitute for proof someone wants it, and having nothing built doesn't count against you.	NO BUILD YET

ONE WE DIDN'T ASK — BUT YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO ANSWER

What would make you walk away from this idea? Being able to name the evidence that would change your mind is, on its own, a strong signal to anyone evaluating you: it shows you're testing a belief rather than defending one. Worth writing down before your next conversation.

IF IT'D HELP TO TALK IT THROUGH

If you'd rather not do this part alone, **Session 1 — 2 · Phase 01: Discover & Design** of Builder 1.0 is built around this exact move. But nothing on the previous page requires a program, or us — start there either way.

Book a 20-minute conversation: opportunitymachine.org
Call: (337) 769-4085 · **Email:** info@opportunitymachine.org
The Acadiana Founder Brief: one email a month, unsubscribe anytime.